JFK, JFK

Third Draft

October 16, 2026

CLASS READING

Stage Directions:	Ranveer
Wang Qiang:	Zane
Boy:	Lucas
Chao:	Josh
Officer:	Bruno
Woman / Sister Xia:	Mia
Driver A / Driver B / GPT:	Yuqi
KTV Attendant / Mechanic:	Keara
Middle-Aged Man / Chinese Officer:	Max

Note: Dialogue is in Mandarin unless set in *italics*, which marks lines spoken in English.

EXT. PARKING LOT EXIT - EARLY MORNING

Not quite dawn. The parking lot exit is dim. In the distance, a seven-seater van sits beside a concrete pillar.

WANG QIANG enters from the far end of the frame, bundled in a puffy down jacket that makes him look round as a ball. A crossbody bag hangs on his chest. His left hand grips a giant cup of tea; his right clutches two phones, one of them open to the drivers' group walkie-talkie.

DRIVER A (V.O.)
JFK, JFK. JFK, JFK.

Wang Qiang reaches the van. It's filthy, caked in black mud spatter and layers of dust. He fishes the key out of his jacket pocket, unlocks it, and slides the door open.

INT. VAN - CONTINUOUS

Freezing inside. A thin mist clings to the edges of the windows. Stuck to the dashboard in front of the passenger seat is a little solar-powered toy -- a flower that's supposed to sway. Right now it's perfectly still.

Wang Qiang drops into the driver's seat, tosses his bag onto the passenger seat, and clips both phones into the mount by the steering wheel. He holds down the talk button on one of them.

WANG QIANG
I can do JFK today. Send me the trip.

He wedges the tea into the cup holder, puts the key in, and turns it. The engine coughs to life.

He cranks the AC dial to heat and presses the button. Nothing. He leans his face toward the vent -- a foul stench hits him and he jerks back. He twists the dial a few more times, slaps the panel. Still nothing.

WANG QIANG
Fuck.

He rubs his hands together, blows into his palms, then pulls the tea out of the cup holder and stuffs it inside his jacket. Warmth spreads against his chest.

EXT. FLUSHING STREETS - EARLY MORNING

The van rolls through the streets of Flushing.

INT. VAN - CONTINUOUS

Wang Qiang opens ChatGPT on his phone, taps voice mode, and talks to it a little clumsily.

WANG QIANG
Today, three p.m., JFK airport. Put it on my schedule for today.

GPT (V.O.)
Okay. I've added the trip to your calendar.

Wang Qiang looks at the screen with a satisfied smile, then checks the time.

EXT. KTV PARKING LOT - EARLY MORNING

The van turns into a parking lot. Two other seven-seaters are already lined up outside a KTV karaoke bar; one is loading passengers and getting ready to leave. Wang Qiang rolls down his window.

WANG QIANG
Morning.

DRIVER B
Morning.

Wang Qiang pulls to the back of the line. Only one car left ahead of him.

CUT TO:

INT. VAN - LATER

Wang Qiang opens a plastic bag: one steamed bun and an ear of corn. He eats while scrolling Douyin.

A chill creeps in, and he fiddles with the AC buttons again. Meanwhile, another group spills out of the KTV: a KTV ATTENDANT in a waiter's suit, a MIDDLE-AGED MAN, and a young couple.

Wang Qiang watches through the window. The middle-aged man ushers the couple into the car ahead. Even after it pulls away, he keeps waving after it, bowing and scraping. Wang Qiang inches forward and stops beside him. The attendant helps the man -- too drunk to walk -- into the van, then comes around to the driver's window and offers Wang Qiang a cigarette. Wang Qiang takes it and tucks it behind his ear.

KTV ATTENDANT
Brother Qiang, take care of this one for me today. I'll text you his address.

WANG QIANG
No problem. I'm off.

Wang Qiang drives away.

EXT. QUEENS STREETS - EARLY MORNING

The van cruises down a street in Queens, a cheesy Chinese dance remix blasting inside.

INT. VAN - CONTINUOUS

Wang Qiang glances in the rearview mirror. The middle-aged man is out cold in the back seat. Wang Qiang turns the music down.

MIDDLE-AGED MAN
Don't stop... keep the music going!

Wang Qiang has no choice but to turn it back up. He hums along.

EXT. RESIDENTIAL STREET - DAY

The music cuts off abruptly. The van is now parked on a street beside a house.

WANG QIANG
Sir, we're here.

He turns around to the sleeping man and pats him.

WANG QIANG
Sir, wake up!

No response. Wang Qiang sighs, pulls one phone from the mount, gets out, and walks around to the back.

Stepping out, he notices a police car parked not far behind him. His movements turn careful. He opens the back door, snaps a photo of the man sleeping, then pats his cheek. His face is a knot of worry.

He gets back in the driver's seat and makes a call.

WANG QIANG
Hello? It's me. The guy I just picked up passed out in my car -- I can't wake him up. He hasn't paid yet! What am I supposed to do? I can't exactly drag him out.

As he talks, he eyes the bag slung across the man's body, then looks back at the police car behind them, growing more and more agitated. We can't make out what the other end is saying. He takes the cigarette from behind his ear, lights it, and takes a drag.

And so they sit in the van: one awake, one asleep.

CUT TO:

INT. VAN - LATER

It's nearly noon. Wang Qiang's eyes are shut, brows furrowed, arms crossed over his chest, head resting on the window. The walkie-talkie app suddenly chimes. He half-opens his eyes and taps the phone.

DRIVER A (V.O.)
American Dream to Flushing.
American Dream to Flushing.

Wang Qiang locks the screen. Behind him, the man slowly sits up and rubs his eyes. Then his stomach lurches; a retching sound rises from deep in his chest.

Wang Qiang flies out of the van, yanks the back door open, and lets him throw up onto the street.

EXT. UNDER AN ELEVATED HIGHWAY - NOON

The van passes beneath an overpass, threading through the cracks of the city.

INT. VAN - CONTINUOUS

Stopped at a red light, Wang Qiang grabs the takeout pork trotter rice from the passenger seat and shovels in a big mouthful. His phone rings. He sets the container back down and answers.

WANG QIANG
Hey, honey.
(pause)
What? Early dismissal today?
Shit.
I'm going right now.

He yanks the wheel left into the U-turn lane. The roar of a jet engine swells in the distance.

EXT. PLAYGROUND - NOON

A huge airliner skims low overhead, its roar deafening. At the same moment, a toy airplane sails into the foreground, glides over the slide and the swings, and lands on the rubber-mulch ground. We hear a kid making the engine noise with his mouth.

BOY (O.S.)
The plane has arrived. Passengers, remember to pay --

On top of the slide, the BOY (8) and a GIRL crouch in a corner, playing with the toy plane.

In the distance, Wang Qiang hurries along the sidewalk. He walks up to a WOMAN, says hello, and bows slightly in thanks.

WANG QIANG
Thank you so much, sorry for the trouble!

WOMAN
It's nothing. The two of them had a great time.
(calling out)
Hey -- no fighting!

Over by the slide, the boy and girl are squabbling -- fighting over the plane. The boy can't win; the girl snatches it away. He scrunches his brow, twists the hem of his shirt in both fists, tears welling in his eyes. Seeing this, the girl tosses the plane on the ground in disgust, giving it back.

Wang Qiang and the woman rush over to their kids. Wang Qiang scoops the boy up.

INT. VAN - NOON

The boy sits in the passenger seat hugging his backpack, gnawing on the half ear of corn left over from Wang Qiang's breakfast.

WANG QIANG
You have to buy a ticket to ride a plane. Next time I'll take you on one, then you'll see.

The boy keeps chewing and ignores him. Wang Qiang rubs his head.

The boy puts the cob back in the plastic bag and looks up. He notices the solar flower on the dashboard, motionless.

He tries to pry it loose -- it's glued down tight, won't budge. So he opens the glove compartment and takes out a flashlight.

EXT. HIGHWAY - AFTERNOON

The van weaves through highway traffic. A sign overhead: JFK AIRPORT.

INT. VAN - CONTINUOUS

Wang Qiang sticks a nasal inhaler up his nostril and takes a minty hit to wake himself up. He pulls the dispatch phone -- still running the fleet walkie-talkie -- out together with its mount and shoves it into the center console.

He checks the time on his other phone, finds the airport customer's number in the fleet group chat, and calls.

WANG QIANG
Hello? I'm the driver picking you up. Got your luggage yet?

CHAO (V.O.)
Just got off the plane. Still in line for customs.

WANG QIANG
Okay, call me when you get your bags. What's your full name?

CHAO (V.O.)
(pause)
I have to give my name to take a cab?

WANG QIANG
Airport cops are strict. If a cop asks, tell them I'm your cousin. Don't say it's a cab. My name is Wang Qiang -- remember that.

Meanwhile, the boy clicks on the flashlight and aims it at the flower's little solar panel. Under the beam, the flower finally begins to sway side to side.

Another plane passes overhead. The boy shields his eyes from the sun with one hand and looks out the window.

EXT. JFK - UPPER LEVEL ARRIVALS - AFTERNOON

A seven-seater cuts across from the pickup lane. At the curb, CHAO (21, Asian) stands guard over five huge suitcases, phone raised, scanning the traffic. The van comes in fast and brakes hard right in front of him. Wang Qiang jumps out, doesn't even say hello, goes straight to the back, pops the trunk, and grabs the first suitcase. Before Chao can react, Wang Qiang is already on the second.

The third row folded flat, the suitcases go in like Tetris blocks. Wang Qiang practically kicks the last one in. He glances back at the curb -- far off, an officer in a reflective vest is looking their way. In the passenger seat, the boy watches all of it, not knowing how to help his dad.

The boy watches Wang Qiang slam the trunk, jump back into the driver's seat, and hit the automatic door. Chao climbs in after him and exchanges a look with the boy in the front seat.

WANG QIANG
Hurry up, little bro. TLC's coming.

CHAO
TLC?

Before the words are out, someone raps on the passenger window. An OFFICER (35, white) in a reflective uniform and sunglasses motions for them to roll it down.

OFFICER
TLC. Hands off your steering wheel.

The officer peers inside and sees Chao and the boy. Wang Qiang gestures wildly.

WANG QIANG
Family, my family. This my son.

OFFICER
You're suspected of running an unlicensed taxi.

CHAO
He's my cousin.

WANG QIANG
Cousin... brother!

OFFICER
You two, show me your IDs.

They fumble their IDs over. The officer points at Wang Qiang.

OFFICER
What's his name?

WANG QIANG
Yang Chao -- I mean, Chao Yang.

OFFICER
(to Chao)
What about his?

A thousand names flash through Chao's head, but he can't remember the one Wang Qiang told him on the phone. The silence stretches. The air freezes.

OFFICER
Alright. Chao, right? Get your luggage out of the car. You can't be riding with him.

Chao hesitates, then scrambles out and starts unloading his bags.

The officer walks around to the front and writes down the plate. Wang Qiang jumps out to argue.

Through the window, the boy watches his father arguing with the officer and seems to sink into the seat. He looks back: Chao has pulled out every suitcase and shut the trunk. Then a CHINESE OFFICER (40s) walks up from behind and joins the argument.

The white officer signs two tickets, hands them to Wang Qiang, and leaves. Once he's gone, the Chinese officer coaxes Wang Qiang back into the van.

CHINESE OFFICER
Brother, don't blame us. Find a way to get a legal TLC plate.

WANG QIANG
TLC plates are impossible to get these days.

The Chinese officer looks helpless too. He pulls a business card from his pocket and glances left and right to make sure no other officers are around.

CHINESE OFFICER
For the tickets, call this lawyer. Now go.

He spots the boy in the passenger seat and gives him a little wave.

BOY
Dad, I'm a little cold.

Tickets in one hand, Wang Qiang jabs the AC button with the other. Still nothing. He pounds the steering wheel.

INT. VAN / AUTOMATIC CAR WASH - DAY

Outside, the car wash roars louder and louder. Foam piles up layer by layer on the windows, blotting out the lights of the wash bay bit by bit. The van grows darker and darker.

INT. AUTO REPAIR SHOP - AFTERNOON

A MECHANIC (30s) is buried halfway under the hood, flashlight raised, searching for something. A SECOND MECHANIC walks over to Wang Qiang and the boy holding a tattered piece of engine insulation.

MECHANIC
Your AC wire's been chewed through. New York rats get cold at night -- they made a nest in your engine. Happens a lot.

Wang Qiang takes it and examines it. The insulation is torn clean through the middle, the edges covered in bite marks. He sniffs it and whips his face away.

MECHANIC
This pad has to be replaced, I'll add it to the bill. Fixing the AC wire is gonna take at least an hour.

Rats in the engine -- the boy perks right up. He runs to the front of the van, gets down on his belly to peer underneath,

pulls the flashlight from his pocket, and shines it inside.

EXT. FLUSHING STREET - AFTERNOON

Father and son walk hand in hand down the sidewalk. Wang Qiang holds the business card. They turn a corner; he looks up at a sign on the street: AH XIA LAW OFFICE. They push the door open and climb the stairs.

INT. LAW OFFICE ENTRANCE - CONTINUOUS

Wang Qiang and the boy reach the office door just as a MAN about Wang Qiang's age comes out holding a few documents. Wang Qiang pushes the door open and goes in.

INT. LAW OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

A cramped office stacked with manila folders. A bilingual Chinese-English price list is taped to the wall.

SISTER XIA (early 50s) sits behind the desk, just hanging up the phone.

SISTER XIA
Sit. What's the problem?

Wang Qiang sits. The boy stands beside him. Wang Qiang takes out the two crumpled tickets and slides them across.

WANG QIANG
Got stopped by TLC at JFK today.

Sister Xia puts on her glasses, looks them over, and sighs.

SISTER XIA
This is a tough one. Two of them.
(looks up)
The car's not yours, is it?

WANG QIANG
Rented. I pay by the month.

SISTER XIA
Let me translate for you: one ticket, two thousand, written to you. The other, two thousand, written to the owner.

Wang Qiang freezes. The boy looks at him.

WANG QIANG
Go wait outside.

The boy walks out. The door chime rings.

WANG QIANG
So what do I do?

SISTER XIA
Two hundred fifty. Our lawyer goes to court for you, tries to get them dismissed. If not, we get it down to five hundred. No guarantees.

WANG QIANG
How does that work?

SISTER XIA
We pick the court date first. If we land a judge we know, we play the relationship card.
(pulls out a form)
If you want to do it, give me your documents.

Wang Qiang has already taken out a plastic document folder, everything inside arranged neatly.

INT. LAW OFFICE ENTRANCE - CONTINUOUS

The boy stands outside the glass door. Through the faded red lettering, he sees his father hunched over, handing over documents one by one, talking with Sister Xia. No sound.

EXT. FLUSHING STREET - DUSK

Wang Qiang and the boy come out of the stairwell. Wang Qiang starts walking; the boy stays rooted to the spot. Wang Qiang turns around and waves him over.

WANG QIANG
Being difficult again?

Wang Qiang walks back, lifts the boy up onto his shoulders, and keeps walking.

WANG QIANG
Don't tell Mom about today, okay?

Wang Qiang walks down the street with the boy on his shoulders. In the distant sky a plane passes. The boy looks up at it.

EXT. MONTAGE - DUSK

-- People crossing at a crosswalk

-- A train crossing a bridge

-- Outside a market, people carrying bags big and small

-- An amusement park at dusk

THE END